Week 4 Notes: The Emergence of Rock 'n' Roll

Sep 23, 2026 · @Michael J

Rock 'n' roll in the postwar era — guitar cultures, genre, and the first stars. Merged from the Week 4.1 and 4.2 slides and both lecture recordings. The Friday lecture on "That's All Right" is not yet included.

Where We Are (Midterm Framing)

This is the midway point before the midterm — the week that ties together what has come so far and opens the themes for the next few weeks.

The review sheet arrives by October 5, possibly the Friday before. It covers key themes week by week, roughly two notes per week, and a playlist of songs to know in more detail.

On dates — don't panic. The instructor is explicitly *not* testing whether you know a song is 1952 vs 1953 vs 1954. What matters is placing it in the right period: is this a mid-1950s song, a 1930s song, a 1960s song? Position it on the broader timeline and know what is happening in it at that moment.

Note-taking advice. As songs are played and discussed, write down why they matter — fill in the gaps around the slides rather than transcribing everything.

Pacing shift. Up to now the course has jumped around week to week. After this week it settles into decades, spending much longer on the 1960s. The course runs to the end of the 1960s before winter, then returns to the 1960s later for the British Invasion.

Finishing Ray Charles: "What'd I Say" (1959)

Soul becomes a term people use as the 1950s end, even though the soulful sonic characteristics are already present mid-decade ("I Got a Woman," 1954). This track is where the genre crystallises.

What to hear

- **Melisma** — singing a single syllable across several notes, something Charles is known for
- Shouts and body sounds; the voice and body carrying the listener somewhere the lyrics alone cannot

- **Call and response** between Charles and the Raelettes, heightened far beyond what blues examples had done
- Piano-driven energy and a strong sense of improvisation — exactly the spontaneity audiences wanted on record in the rock ′n′ roll era

Origins and format. The song was born at the end of a live performance in 1958 when Charles and the band had time to fill. At seven minutes it will not fit on one side of a seven-inch record (about three and a half minutes) or into radio′s slot of the same length, so it was released as Part 1 and Part 2, with variations recorded that toned down the vocal sounds stations objected to. The instrumental breakdown at the halfway point is where it splits.

Controversy. Radio stations and cultural authorities — TV programmes, newspaper writers — found the second half too overtly sexual. Tame by today′s standards, but it lands inside the moral politics of the late 1950s, the same politics that shaped what television would allow of Elvis′s dancing. The moral panic was sharpest around songs resonating across young Black *and* white audiences.

Note on the title. You will see it as both "What′d I Say" and "What I Say" — treat them as the same song. Soul returns later with Motown and the mid-to-late 1960s.

Guitar Cultures

The guitar moves to the front of rock ′n′ roll in the 1950s both **sonically** and **visually**. The lecture′s image of Elvis from behind — guitar in hand, a stadium of fans in front of him — captures both at once: the performer at the centre, dressed in black or denim like the rocker and greaser subcultures, tied to the film, motorcycle, and car culture of the day.

The electric guitar′s three properties from the slides: **mobility**, **"lead" (melody and solos)**, **"rhythm" (chord sequences)**, and **electrification**.

How electrification works. A plucked string vibrates; that motion disturbs the magnetic field around a **pickup** (a magnet wrapped in a wire coil); the moving field induces a current in the coil; the current goes to the amp. Around **1938** electrified instruments start appearing in country, western, and rhythm and blues.

Why it matters beyond volume. Once the sound is an electrical signal, you can manipulate it. Pedals and filters sit between guitar and amp, altering the signal before amplification — so the instrument no longer has to sound one way. It can be distorted past recognition, or turned through amplification and feedback into a wall of noise. The stacks

of amplifiers at a rock or metal show, plugged in or not, are a **symbol of the visceral power of the instrument**. Amplification is part of what gives us rock, and part of what lets rock fragment into subgenres.

The same logic extends into the studio: a recording no longer has to be one perfect take. Editing, re-editing, cutting, and overdubbing become tools — covered in coming weeks.

The Guitars Themselves

The point is not brand awareness — it is that particular models map onto particular styles and onto *ideas* about the instrument.

Guitar	Maker	Introduced	Character	Associated with
Telecaster	Fender	c. 1950	Two pickups; brighter, twangier	Country, blues, surf; Muddy Waters, Bruce Springsteen
Stratocaster	Fender	1954	Three pickups, solid body, very versatile	Wide range of contexts; sits mid-timeline
Les Paul	Gibson	c. 1952	Solid body, versatile — Gibson's answer to the Strat	Broad use
SG	Gibson	early 1960s	Looks "more evil" — horns at the neck	Hard rock, hardcore, metal; Angus Young (AC/DC), Sister Rosetta Tharpe
Rickenbacker	Rickenbacker	1932 onward	Chiming, jangly; lower-output pickups	The Byrds, The Beatles — George Harrison; the British Invasion sound

Two things worth remembering from this list.

First, **Springsteen's worn Telecaster** is a lesson in constructed authenticity. A new Telecaster in a guitar tech's hands would sound no different — but the beaten-up instrument *communicates* something about working-class New Jersey and the long, hard-working show. The look does work the sound does not.

Second, **Sister Rosetta Tharpe playing an SG** on 1960s television — a 1940s song, performed in 1960, on a guitar that had only just come out. The instructor likes the clip partly for that anachronistic pleasure: a menacing-looking guitar in a gospel context.

Rickenbacker were the first to produce electric guitars, going back to 1932, before the mass-produced 1950s models.

Lead vs Rhythm: How the Guitar Frames a Rock Band

Something to listen for over the coming weeks:

- **Rhythm guitar** — chordal pacing maintained through the song, usually while someone sings. Rhythm can live elsewhere too (piano, bass), but in a rock band someone is typically committed to holding those sequences.
- **Lead guitar** — the melody and the solos.

This is a tendency, not a rule. Early Beatles records put very melodic bass lines in the primary melodic role — McCartney writing bass parts that drive the song rather than merely underpin it.

Rock 'n' Roll as a Genre

Rock 'n' roll marks the **Anglo-American dominance of post-WWII popular music**. Treat it less as a purely musical label than as the **language, rhythm, and ideology of a generation**.

1955: a new form of rhythm and blues (plus other genres), **marketed to an interracial teenage market**.

Youth and the generation gap

- A celebration of difference and pleasure — parents vs youth
- "Rocking and rolling" was a pseudonym for both dancing and sex
- Performance matters as much as sound: these performers are not sitting on a stool, they are dancing and moving
- **1956–76: rock dominates popular music**; in the 1960s "rock 'n' roll" becomes "Rock"

Binary oppositions with pop — rock as authentic/serious against pop as commercial/disposable. The slides flag these as **ideological constructions**, not descriptions of the music.

Alan Freed, the influential DJ, is the figure who brought this music to a mass audience — he recurs when we get to Little Richard.

The Two Rhythmic Foundations

The slides define early rock 'n' roll as a **"boogie woogie rhythm with emphasis on backbeat."** Both halves need unpacking.

Boogie woogie. A rolling, repeated figure usually in the piano's left hand or the bass — a low, driving sound underneath everything. The reference recording is **Clarence "Pinetop" Smith, "Pinetop's Boogie Woogie" (1928/1929)**, which named the style for popular music by calling it out in the lyrics. It is already present in Sister Rosetta Tharpe's gospel/race-record crossovers. Listen for it in the deeper keys, not the bright upper ones.

Backbeat. Count **one-TWO-three-FOUR** — emphasis on beats 2 and 4. Recordings in this era play that up deliberately, because it tells listeners where to dance.

> The instructor's test: play a track and imagine where you would clap. If you ground yourself in the two and the four, you look like you know what you're doing — unlike the wedding guest dancing to the vocal melody or the guitar solo.

That simple device is what let all sorts of listeners come together around the dancing element of rock 'n' roll.

Straight vs syncopated. Earlier big band music and Western Swing tend toward a more **syncopated** backbeat — slightly off, still danceable. Straightforward rock 'n' roll lands much more squarely on two and four, and that squareness is what drives the song forward.

Neither element is new: both have ties to ragtime, gospel, and rhythm and blues. What is new is the moment when they come together and get popularised.

Case Study: The Genealogy of "Rock Around the Clock"

This is the core argument of the lecture. "Rock Around the Clock" stands in for the sound of early rock 'n' roll — but it is the endpoint of a chain, and the chain is what the standard story erases.

```
flowchart LR
  A["Pinetop's Boogie Woogie<br/>Clarence Smith, 1928/29"] --> B["Rock the
Joint<br/>Jimmy Preston, 1949"]
  B --> C["Rock the Joint<br/>Bill Haley, 1952"]
  C --> D["Rock Around the Clock<br/>Bill Haley, 1954"]
  D --> E["Film: Blackboard Jungle<br/>Rock Around the Clock, 1956"]
```

Each step adds something. Preston's 1949 record brings the handclaps in on the backbeat and has a messy, overlapping sax mixed right into everything — you can hear a room of people dancing. Haley's 1952 version is musically very close to what comes two years later, right down to a guitar solo that sounds almost identical to the famous one.

Why 1954 and not 1952? Timing and placement, not musical novelty. Haley came out of Western Swing, which was declining after the war — moving into rock 'n' roll was simply more lucrative. By 1954 the song could be repackaged, retitled, and mapped onto films featuring the bands and the young consumers dancing along (*Rock Around the Clock*, 1956; *Don't Knock the Rock*, 1957; Columbia Pictures). That is what made it a youth anthem.

What to hear in the 1954 record

- Just over two minutes — tight, radio-sized structure
- Snare accents in the first half, settling into a comfortable backbeat in the second
- Lead solo breaks traded between saxophone and electric guitar (the order differs between record and film versions)
- Boogie rhythm now on **bass guitar** rather than piano bass
- Amplification and the electric guitar audible on record

The critical point. These songs get named as foundational, and that naming is a process that erases the contributions of many others. Ask not only *what* influenced rock 'n' roll but **how and why these particular songs came to be cited as influential** — and treat them as examples, not as the only ones that matter.

Postwar Youth Culture (Week 4.2)

The slides recap it as four things: **style and spending, popular cinema, car culture and teenage experience, youth vs parent culture.**

Why the divide was so sharp. After the war, youth came up in a materially different world: more leisure time, more spending money, more freedom to be out listening to records and socialising with friends than was common before the war. The parent generation struggled to make sense of it, especially around morality. "Youth as a celebration of difference and pleasure" means difference *from the parent generation* — identity found through consuming popular culture.

Where the term "rock and roll" comes from. It has no single origin. **Alan Freed** had a radio programme called the *Rock and Roll Dance Party*, and others — Paul Bascomb among late-1940s performers — used the phrase in songs. Influential DJs playing records shaped not just the sound of the moment but the **ideology of a generation**.

It also arrived visually, through advertisements, print, and television. The lecture's photograph — three young people around a car, gelled hair, leather jackets, denim — is the iconic 1950s image: the vehicle as a symbol of new leisure, mobility, and friendship.

Radio moved with them. In the 1950s radio stopped being the main thing in the living room (television took that) and found new life in **transistor radios** and **car radios**. So when DJs broke these songs to youth audiences, much of that happened in a vehicle — which is what "Maybellene" is about.

From "Rock 'n' Roll" to "Rock"

Dropping the "and roll" marks a real shift. **Rock 'n' roll** is tied to the rockabilly and boogie-woogie rhythm, strict 4/4, a clear backbeat, and audible debts to blues, Western Swing, and country. **Rock** — the Beatles, the Beach Boys, later Led Zeppelin and Pink Floyd — is less reliant on those rhythms and expands what a recording can be, largely through new studio technology. Those earlier debts get downplayed in the process.

Rock framed against pop. Across the 1960s, 70s and 80s, rock gets coded as **authentic** and **masculine** — loud bands of men — against a **feminised** sphere of pop. This operates at the level of the record industry, in how genres are packaged, and in how bands and listeners come to believe the distinction.

You can see it in the performance practices: energetic male figures like Chuck Berry and Elvis, with young fans (often young women) brought into the star's orbit through television and live shows — fan reaction framed in the press as "losing their minds."

Chuck Berry

What makes him structurally different. Berry is a **guitarist, not a pianist**, and he is **songwriter, singer, performer, and guitarist at once**. He is not working from already-recorded material in the way many contemporaries were — this is original composition.

Set that against the **Tin Pan Alley model**: collaborative, behind-the-scenes songwriting, with separate performers bringing the song to life. Popular music swings back toward Tin Pan Alley within a few years, then back again with the British Invasion, where the Beatles do what Berry did.

"Johnny B. Goode" (1958)

- A relatable story: a young boy from the country who succeeds with the electric guitar — the instrument's ideological power turned into narrative
- **Increased tempo**, audible in the lyric delivery, the guitar playing, and a prominent, fast-moving backbeat
- Heavy soloing; a competing lead between piano and guitar at once, giving it a messy live-performance energy — closer to "What'd I Say" than to the controlled "Rock Around the Clock"
- Still clearly an extension of rhythm and blues, with new elements added rather than old ones left behind
- Alan Freed was instrumental in bridging audiences, at a time when media circulation still assumed segregated listeners

"Maybellene" (1955)

- Derived from **Bob Wills's "Ida Red"** — Western Swing, i.e. country and western. Berry is pulled by R&B on one side and country on the other
- An interviewer in the Brackett reading finds it odd that Berry is a country and western fan; that surprise is itself about race, given how the industry had sorted performers and audiences into race records and hillbilly. Berry on "Ida Red": *maybe a little faster, but basically it was country*
- Lyrics: the Cadillac, the Ford, the speed, bumper to bumper — but underneath, a relatable story of one person chasing another
- Form: a variation on the 12-bar structure — two repeated lines resolving differently — with a long extended guitar solo in the middle

Performance (French television, 1958). The guitar becomes **a thing to dance with**: turned upside down, moved up and down, not treated as a proper instrument to be played politely. Television was new, and it added a dimension to consuming popular music — you could now watch performers and get close to them. The guitar playing that cites Berry runs forward to Angus Young, and backward to Sister Rosetta Tharpe and T-Bone Walker.

The broader lesson: once industry, radio, and airplay get behind a figure with wildly successful songs, that machinery does the ideological work of welding youth culture to rock culture — which is why it is worth asking how and why it happened.

Little Richard

Where the energy lives. With Chuck Berry the guitar communicates the energy; with Little Richard it is **the voice first, the piano second**. He plays piano physically — leg up on the instrument, moving around it, band members climbing on top with a saxophone — and his vocal contribution comes straight out of gospel, adding bodily energy to rock 'n' roll far more than Berry's singing does.

He is also among the **first credited with foregrounding the backbeat**, putting it front and centre in a way that made the songs plainly danceable.

Born 1932, Georgia. Songwriting **extroverted and energetic**; performance **wild dancing, often on top of the piano**, with a large pompadour, liberal use of make-up, and flashy clothing.

Makeup, drag, and strategy. Little Richard had performed in drag in vaudeville groups and wore heavy makeup and wigs. He has reflected on the androgynous look as a way to **downplay the sexuality** reaching youth audiences and to be seen as less of a threat:

> "We were breaking through the racial barrier…We decided that my image should be crazy and way-out so that the adults would think I was harmless…" (Brackett)

Read this against the parent generation's anxiety about **young audiences watching Black male performers**, and against the racism still embedded in the record industry when audiences were largely segregated. Minstrelsy and music publishers whose wealth came from slaveholding were not distant history in the 1950s.

"Tutti Frutti" (1955) — his first major hit after unsuccessful early-1950s recordings. Loud, prominent vocals; distinct backbeat; fast boogie-shuffle rhythm, stop-time breaks, and the "trademark falsetto whoops." Described as **the sound of the birth of rock 'n' roll**.

"Long Tall Sally" in *Don't Knock the Rock* (the follow-up to *Rock Around the Clock*). Watch two things. First, how the **audience is framed**: clapping along on the backbeat, the danceability made visible; Bill Haley is seated at one of the tables. Second, the staging: it looks like a Count Basie-style big band with rotating riffs and solos, but instead of a soloist standing up in formation, members *leave* the formation and play on top of the piano — a new use of stage space, and exactly what the parent generation found inappropriate.

Comparison worth memorising (both 1955): "Tutti Frutti" vs "Maybellene." Both have the backbeat. Little Richard puts the rock 'n' roll elements **in the voice**, blending gospel with the backbeat, and attracts the term "rock and roll" more readily; Chuck Berry puts them **in the guitar**, and draws more comparisons to rhythm and blues.

These are also the songs young British bands — the Beatles among them — would cover and repackage for American audiences a few years later, with full band formations rather than a single guitarist.

Elvis Presley: Background

1935–1977, Memphis.

- Early musical experience in the **Pentecostal services of the First Assembly of God Church** — the same gospel grounding as Ray Charles
- Also country music, blues, and rhythm and blues, absorbed from radio and records
- **1954:** aged 19, discovered by **Sam Phillips of Sun Records** (Memphis)

Learning by ear. Like Ray Charles, Elvis came from poverty in the South and learned music by listening rather than reading it. That is a structural difference between high-art classical training and popular stardom: you can pick up a guitar or drums, learn by ear, and be extremely successful.

Why Sun Records matters. Sam Phillips's label was small, innovative, and odd next to the majors, and it shaped the early Elvis sound. When he moved to a major label, those labels tried to replicate it — with some success, but never fully capturing the gritty energy of the Sun studio. This is where **producers and labels become audible** as shapers of popular music, not just distributors of it.

"That's All Right" (1954)

His first major recording, on Sun Records, produced by Sam Phillips.

The source. Originally performed by **Arthur Crudup (1946)**; a 1949 version titled "That's All Right, Mama." The familiar pattern — a Black blues performer's material becoming a white performer's breakthrough.

The trio. Scotty Moore on lead guitar, Bill Black on bass, and Presley on what the slides call "crude" rhythm guitar — the small, economical formation traced back through honky-tonk and Chicago blues.

Rockabilly — a fast style of country mixed with rhythm and blues. The record carries elements of both, though listeners did not always identify them as such.

The voice is what drew attention:

> "swooping almost two octaves at times, changing timbres from a croon to a growl instantaneously, he seemed not so much to be synthesizing preexisting styles as to be juxtaposing them…" (Brackett 111)

> "…no previous white singer had so successfully forged an individual style clearly rooted in a contemporaneous African American idiom" (Brackett)

Note the precise claim: **juxtaposing, not synthesizing**. The styles sit next to each other audibly rather than blending — part of why the record sounds unresolved and exciting.

"Heartbreak Hotel" (1956)

The move from Sun to the majors: **Tom Parker (RCA) purchases Presley's contract for $35,000**, and this becomes his **first RCA Victor single**.

The headline fact: **Top 5 on the Pop, Rhythm and Blues, and Country charts simultaneously**. Crossover in its most literal form — one record succeeding in all three of the industry's separate markets at once, which is precisely what the categories were built to prevent.

The sound is **expanded** relative to the Sun trio — the beginning of the move toward a fuller, more produced record.

"Hound Dog" (1956) and Big Mama Thornton

Elvis's version **"radically transformed"** a song that was already a hit — and the original matters as much as the cover.

Willie Mae "Big Mama" Thornton (1926–1984), rhythm and blues singer and songwriter. Her "Hound Dog" was a **1952 R&B hit that sold nearly two million copies**. Four years later a white performer's version becomes the one everyone remembers. Keep her name attached to the song.

Elvis's version has increasingly heavy instrumentation — piano, drums, and background singers — moving closer to mainstream pop and away from the spare Sun sound.

The television controversy. After a performance on the *Milton Berle Show*, a second performance drew real backlash: Ed Sullivan called it **"unfit for family viewing,"** and the press coined **"Elvis the Pelvis."** Same moral-politics terrain as the "What'd I Say" bans — but now on national television, where the body is visible as well as audible.

"King of Rock 'n' Roll"?

The slides pose it as a question, with two answers to **why Elvis stood out from others: race** and **youth/age — teen idol**.

On race. The title echoes **Paul Whiteman being dubbed "the King of Jazz"** (Week 2) — a recurring pattern in which white performers are crowned for music initiated, played, and often popularised by Black performers. Elvis worked extensively from Black blues source material and turned it into major-label hits, so labelling him "the King" **erases that history and those contributions**. The lecture points to Chuck D's line in Public Enemy's "Fight the Power" as the sharpest statement of that injustice.

On youth. Elvis was considerably younger than Chuck Berry and much closer in age to his audience — a teen idol in a way the others structurally could not be. He also met the categories record labels, marketing, and advertising could use strategically: look, style, dress, and a televisual presence.

Style as the hinge. A sense of style, musical and personal, made him the **focal point of media reaction to early rock 'n' roll** and the **inspiration for some of the most important rock musicians to follow**.

Celebrity culture. More than with Little Richard or Chuck Berry, Elvis attracts a growing fascination with a performer's **interior and private life** — a celebrity to be consumed across many aspects, not just a music star. Graceland is the visible endpoint of a trajectory from a two-room house in Tupelo. His early death gets woven into those accounts too. So this is also a story about the rise of **postwar celebrity culture**.

Hold both halves at once: a complicated figure genuinely shaped by the gospel, country, and blues he grew up with, *and* the beneficiary of a racialised industry that made his version the one that counted.

Rock 'n' Roll and the Popular Press (1956)

After the first wave of big hits by **Fats Domino, Chuck Berry, Little Richard, and Elvis**, articles on rock 'n' roll began appearing in mainstream newspapers and magazines — the *New York Times*, *Time*, *Newsweek*, *Life*. The press consistently drew connections between rock 'n' roll and **sex, violence, and juvenile delinquency**.

The language used to describe audiences, quoted exactly:

- "snake-dancing around town and smashing windows"
- "communicable disease"
- "cannibalistic and tribalistic"
- "impels teenagers to affect 'ducktail' haircuts, wear zoot-suits and carry on boisterously at rock-and-roll affairs"
- "the seductive call of rock 'n' roll"

Two things to notice. The **disease metaphor** frames youth culture as contagion — something spreading through a population rather than something young people chose. And **"cannibalistic and tribalistic"** is explicitly racialised language, aimed at music whose Black origins the press understood perfectly well. The moral panic over sex and delinquency and the anxiety over interracial audiences are not two separate panics; they are the same one.

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Melisma	Singing one syllable across several notes — a Ray Charles hallmark
Boogie woogie	Rolling repeated bass figure, usually piano left hand or bass; from Pinetop Smith (1928/29)
Backbeat	Emphasis on beats 2 and 4 (one-TWO-three-FOUR); tells dancers where to move

Term	Definition
Syncopation	Accents falling slightly off the main beats — more common in big band and Western Swing than in straight rock ‘n’ roll
Stop-time break	A brief halt in the accompaniment that exposes voice or solo
Pickup	Magnet + wire coil that converts string vibration into an electrical signal
Amplification	Boosting that signal — also a visual symbol of power (walls of amps)
Lead / rhythm guitar	Melody and solos vs chordal pacing
Lead solo break	An instrumental feature section, traded between sax and guitar in early rock ‘n’ roll
12-bar blues	The repeating harmonic frame underlying much early rock ‘n’ roll, e.g. "Maybellene"
Overdubbing	Layering recorded parts rather than capturing one perfect take
Generation gap	The parents-vs-youth division rock ‘n’ roll both expressed and intensified
Rock vs pop binary	Ideological opposition (authentic/commercial), not a musical description
Rockabilly	A fast style of country mixed with rhythm and blues — the early Elvis/Sun sound
Tin Pan Alley model	Collaborative, behind-the-scenes songwriting with separate performers — the opposite of Chuck Berry's writer-performer-guitarist role
Teen idol	A star close in age to the audience — part of why Elvis stood out from Berry and Little Richard
Transistor radio	Portable radio that moved listening out of the home and into cars and public space
Sun Records	Sam Phillips’s small Memphis label; shaped the early Elvis sound the majors could not replicate

Term	Definition
Three-chart crossover	"Heartbreak Hotel" charting Top 5 on Pop, R&B and Country simultaneously
Juxtaposing vs synthesizing	Brackett's distinction: Presley's voice sets styles side by side rather than blending them
Moral panic	1956 press framing of rock 'n' roll as disease, delinquency, and racialised threat

Listening List

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"What'd I Say"	Ray Charles	1959	Melisma, shouts, call and response with the Raelettes; the instrumental breakdown where Parts 1 and 2 split
"Pinetop's Boogie Woogie"	Clarence "Pinetop" Smith	1928/29	The boogie woogie figure in the low keys; imagine where you would clap — the backbeat is *not* played up
"Rock the Joint"	Jimmy Preston and His Prestonians	1949	Handclaps landing on the backbeat; messy, overlapping sax; the dance floor
"Rock the Joint"	Bill Haley and His Comets	1952	A guitar solo almost identical to the 1954 hit — the sound was there two years early
"Rock Around the Clock"	Bill Haley and His Comets	1954	Snare accents, then a settled backbeat; sax and guitar solo breaks; boogie on bass guitar
"Ida Red"	Bob Wills	—	The Western Swing source for "Maybellene"
"Maybellene"	Chuck Berry	1955	12-bar blues; teenage car narrative

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"Johnny B. Goode"	Chuck Berry	1958	The guitar solo as the centre of the record
"Tutti Frutti"	Little Richard	1955	Fast boogie-shuffle, stop-time breaks, falsetto whoops
"Long Tall Sally"	Little Richard	1956	In Don't Knock the Rock — watch the audience clapping the backbeat and the band leaving formation
"That's All Right, Mama"	Arthur Crudup	1946/1949	The source record behind Presley's debut
"That's All Right"	Elvis Presley	1954	The trio texture; the voice swooping two octaves, croon to growl
"Heartbreak Hotel"	Elvis Presley	1956	Expanded sound after the move to RCA
"Hound Dog"	Willie Mae "Big Mama" Thornton	1952	The original R&B hit — nearly two million copies
"Hound Dog"	Elvis Presley	1956	Piano, drums, background singers; the move toward mainstream pop

Build your own playlist from these — the review sheet works from a list like this one.

Self-Check

- [ ] Define the boogie woogie rhythm and the backbeat, and explain why the backbeat mattered socially, not just musically
- [ ] Trace "Rock Around the Clock" back through Haley 1952, Preston 1949, and Pinetop 1928 — and say what changes at each step
- [ ] Explain why 1954 rather than 1952 made the song a hit
- [ ] Describe how a pickup turns a plucked string into an amplified sound
- [ ] Give two things electrification makes possible beyond volume

- [ ] Distinguish lead from rhythm guitar, and name a case where the bass takes the melodic role
- [ ] Explain why Springsteen's worn Telecaster is an argument about authenticity rather than sound
- [ ] Say what "rock 'n' roll" named in 1955 and who it was marketed to
- [ ] Explain why the rock/pop binary is called an ideological construction
- [ ] Account for the controversy around "What'd I Say," and why the song was split into two parts
- [ ] Explain Little Richard's statement that his image was designed to look harmless to adults
- [ ] Explain why Chuck Berry's role as writer-performer-guitarist matters against the Tin Pan Alley model
- [ ] Trace "Maybellene" to "Ida Red" and say why the interviewer found Berry's country fandom surprising
- [ ] Contrast where the rock 'n' roll energy sits in "Tutti Frutti" vs "Maybellene" (both 1955)
- [ ] Explain Little Richard's account of his image as a strategy, and the racial politics behind it
- [ ] List four material conditions that produced the postwar generation gap
- [ ] Name the source recordings behind "That's All Right" and "Hound Dog," with artists and years
- [ ] Explain Brackett's "juxtaposing, not synthesizing" claim about Presley's voice
- [ ] Say why "Heartbreak Hotel" charting Top 5 on three charts at once is significant
- [ ] Give the two reasons the slides offer for why Elvis stood out, and state the critique of the "King" title
- [ ] Quote two press descriptions of rock 'n' roll audiences and explain what anxiety each encodes

Readings

David Brackett, *The Pop, Rock, and Soul Reader* (Oxford, 2020) supplies the quoted material on these slides. Two from this lecture:

Quote in these notes	Topic
"It was my fascination for the roads, for driving, motoring, which prompted me to write those songs"	Chuck Berry on "Maybellene" and car culture
"We were breaking through the racial barrier… We decided that my image should be crazy and way-out so that the adults would think I was harmless…"	Little Richard on his image as strategy
"swooping almost two octaves at times… juxtaposing them…" — cited as Brackett 111, the one page number the slides give	Presley's voice on "That's All Right"
"…no previous white singer had so successfully forged an individual style clearly rooted in a contemporaneous African American idiom"	Presley and appropriation
Chuck Berry on "Ida Red": maybe a little faster, but basically it was country	Berry's country and western roots

Both sit in the reader alongside the fuller interviews they come from — worth reading whole, because the Little Richard passage in particular is more pointed in context than the excerpt suggests.

Simon Frith, "The Industrialization of Music" (Routledge, 2000, pp. 231–238) underwrites the lecture's central argument here: that "Rock Around the Clock" became the origin story not because of musical novelty but because of timing, film placement, and industry backing — and that this process erases Pinetop Smith, Jimmy Preston, Sister Rosetta Tharpe, and T-Bone Walker. Frith gives you the vocabulary for saying *why* that happens.

The Brackett reader also reprints **1950s press coverage** — the source of the "snake-dancing around town," "communicable disease," and "cannibalistic and tribalistic" descriptions. Read those pieces whole if you can: the slides give the phrases, but the articles show how the sex-and-delinquency panic and the anxiety about interracial audiences were argued as one thing.

Looking ahead — Tom Breihan, "Chubby Checker – 'The Twist'" (*The Number Ones*, Da Capo, 2022, pp. 11–21). This connects backward: Ray Charles said "the dance crazes passed me by. I didn't try to write any jitterbugs or twists." The Twist is the thing he was

declining to write, and it picks up the dance-and-moral-panic thread where this week leaves off.

The slides cite Brackett without page numbers — find these by artist section in the reader.

What the Reading List Suggests (inferred)

Everything in this section is inference from the course reading list — the titles and their order — not from a syllabus or a lecture. Treat it as a guess to check against the review sheet, not as fact.

1. The course is built on single songs as case studies. Six of the eleven readings are chapters about *one track*: "The Twist," "I Want to Hold Your Hand," "Good Vibrations," "Uptown Top Ranking," "F— tha Police." Three come from Breihan's *The Number Ones*, a book organised around chart-topping singles; one from *One Hit Wonders*; one from *One-Track Mind*. This matches what the instructor said about the review sheet — key themes plus **songs to know in more detail** — and suggests exam questions will be anchored to specific tracks rather than broad periods.

2. The chart is a recurring instrument, not just background. A book about #1 hits, plus a Billboard "Forever No. 1" piece, plus the course's attention to Billboard renaming categories (hillbilly → American Folk → Country and Western; race → Rhythm and Blues; "Heartbreak Hotel" on three charts at once). Expect "what does the chart position tell us" to keep being a question.

3. The likely sequence after this week, reading the list in order:

Reading	Points to
Chubby Checker, "The Twist"	Early 1960s dance crazes — picks up directly from this week's dance and moral-panic thread
The Beatles, "I Want to Hold Your Hand"	British Invasion; the return to the band-writes-its-own-songs model
The Beach Boys, "Good Vibrations"	The studio as instrument — the "rock 'n' roll → rock" shift this week describes
Althea and Donna, "Uptown Top Ranking"	Reggae, 1977 — music from outside the US/UK axis

Reading	Points to
NWA, "F— tha Police"	Hip hop, 1988; technology and capitalism in the pop song
Megan Jasper, "Losers"	The 1990s, from an industry insider's perspective
John Darnielle, "For the Back Street Kids"	Pop fandom and critical taste (I can't confirm this piece's argument)

4. Two of the authors are practitioners, not academics. Megan Jasper runs a record label; John Darnielle is a musician. Alongside Brabazon's warning about "the default setting of lyrical analysis, political resistance and masculine authenticity," this suggests the course wants you reading and writing criticism, not only scholarship — useful to know for the annotated playlist.

5. The Anglo-American framing is set up to be broken. Week 4.1 defines rock 'n' roll as "Anglo-American dominance, post-WWII popular music." The presence of reggae and hip hop later means that framing is a starting position the course will complicate, not a conclusion. Likewise the rock/pop binary: the readings that take pop, one-hit wonders and "losers" seriously are probably where that binary gets dismantled.

What to do with this. When the review sheet arrives on or before October 5, check it against points 1 and 3. If it is organised song-by-song, this reading is right and your playlist notes are the main study object.